paign. Many of her bitter critics, like Ghanshyam Tiwari (Rajya Sabha MP) and Gulab Chand Kataria (former leader of the opposition and now Assam governor), have been turfed out of the state. Raje will still have leaders like Union minister Gajendra Shekhawat and Lok Sabha speaker Om Birla to deal with, though.

Similarly, the anti-Shivraj Singh Chouhan group in MP is lobbying hard with the central leadership to shift him to Delhi and fight the assembly polls with a fresh face. Union cabinet minister Narendra Singh Tomar's name is being bandied about as a possible replacement, but since he is "not a pan-MP leader", it is holding the party back.

In Telangana, state unit chief Bandi Sanjay Kumar is struggling to manage the Bharat Rashtra Samithi and Congress turncoats who have joined the party. BJP general secretary Sunil Bansal has been in the state since August 2022 as a 'super in-charge' and is trying to solicit feedback on the way ahead from street meetings by state leaders. In Chhattisgarh, the party is vacillating on whether to let ex-CM Raman Singh take the lead again.

The party still has time to sort out these battles, but its real war is in Karnataka. In the first week of February, the BJP appointed Union minister Dharmendra Pradhan—a party veteran in election management—to anchor the elections in the southern state. The party is battling factionalism, anti-incumbency even as new chief minister Basavaraj Bommai remains embroiled in one controversy after another. There's also the residual anger of the dominant Lingayat community who are upset over B.S. Yediyurappa's removal from the post of CM in 2021. In mid-February, party chief J.P. Nadda met seers from the Lingayat community along with others. The party has also been reaching out to the Vokkaliga and Kurba communities, particularly in the old Mysuru region.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

IN MANY OF THE STATES GOING TO THE POLLS, THE BJP FACES INTRA-PARTY FACTIONALISM. IT IS ALREADY DOING "SURGERY" IN SOME TO SORT THIS OUT

THE ZERO SUM STATES

In 2019, the BJP drew a nought in three southern states—Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Andhra Pradesh—which together send 84 lawmakers to the Lok Sabha. In Tamil Nadu, the BJP has an alliance with AIADMK, which itself is in disarray after a disastrous state election. In Kerala, after experimenting with fringe outfits like the Bharath Dharma Jana Sena or BDJS (a consolidation of the Hindu Ezhava community) and the Kerala Congress (P.C. Thomas faction), the party is trying to get the backing of the Catholic community. Last September, while touring the state, Nadda had closed-door meetings with the archbishops and other senior church members. The BJP had bagged around 13 per cent of the vote in the 2019 general election (the NDA-plus vote share was 15.6 per cent) and even managed to push the CPI(M)-led Left Democratic Front (LDF) to third place in the Thiruvananthapuram Lok Sabha seat. To build the confidence of the community, BJP leaders are talking up matters like PM Modi's invitation to Pope Francis to come to India during his 2021 Rome visit while also highlighting issues that worry the Christians like 'love jihad'. The conversations have continued with leaders of Kerala's churches meeting Union home minister Amit Shah and others in New Delhi. There's also now an RSS-backed Christian 'pressure group', the Bharatiya Christian Sangamam, whose offices in Kochi were inaugurated by the well-regarded Bishop Mathew Arackal. However, the community continues to be apprehensive about the BJP stand on critical issues such as the beef ban and the attacks on its parishes in north India over the 'conversions' issue. Christians make up about 18 per cent of the population in Kerala and conventionally vote for the UDF, "but this time we have a chance", says a party insider.

Similarly, the party is wooing two segments that were earlier considered out of bounds—the Dravidians in Tamil Nadu and Panthic Sikhs in Punjab. Here again, the party is hoping that PM Modi will help make inroads. In November 2022, the PM's constituency, Varanasi in Uttar Pradesh, hosted a month-long festival, the Kashi-Tamil Sangamam, which was visited by